a lawyer's chamber, where she held court with government counsels.

"Any file or paper on Chandrimadi's desk doesn't move without her hawk-like scrutiny. She doesn't get perplexed when handling multiple departments like land and land reforms, urban development, health... even technical ones like planning, statistics and programme monitoring," says a government official. "When given the urban development department, I saw her attend every departmental seminar and workshop; she tried to absorb all that came her way like a sponge." Chandrima, who is also the MoS for health, land and land reforms and programme monitoring, admits that her training as a lawyer has given her an understanding of a wide variety of subjects. A good orator, she's known for her meticulous preparedness and rehearses her lines before any presentation or speech. As finance minister, Chandrima is fortunate to have a mentor in Amit Mitra, the CM's chief advisor on financial matters. But having tabled the budget twice, in 2022 and in 2023, she is fast gaining in confidence.

In fact, Mamata has relied a lot on Chandrima's troubleshooting skills. In the government's regular run-ins with former governor Jagdeep Dhankhar, Chandrima was often at the forefront, countering the former's legal and constitutional assertions. Her strength lies in the logical force of her arguments and her controlled aggression. When a BJP leader made fun of her as a 'half-minister of finance', she struck at the misogynist core of the comment by reminding him that it's because of women that men manage to see the light of day. "I belong to the old school of politics where you were required to be aggressive and loud to be heard," she has reasoned. She is also Mamata's go-to person for the execution of women-related programmes. Chandrima led the *Cholo Gram-e Jai* (let's go to the village) outreach programme from November 2022 to January 2023 to highlight the government's development programmes, especially to

WOMEN MINISTERS IN WEST BENGAL



MAMATA BANERJEE
Chief Minister, Home & Hill Affairs, Health, Land & Land Reforms, Info & Culture, Planning & Stats, Personnel & Admin Reforms



CHANDRIMA BHATTACHARYA
MoS Finance, MoS Health, Land & Land Reforms, Programme Monitoring



DR SHASHI PANJA
Industry & Commerce, Public Enterprise and Industrial Reconstruction, Women and Child Devt & Social Welfare



BIRBAHA HANSDA
Self Help (Ind. charge), MoS Forests



SANDHYARANI TUDU
Paschimanchal Devt (Ind. charge), MoS Parliamentary Affairs



SABINA YEASMIN
MoS Irrigation and Waterways, North Bengal Development



JYOTSNA MANDI
MoS Food and Supplies



SHEULI SAHA
MoS Panchayat and Rural Development Department



TMC's women supporters. Now, as the panchayat polls draw closer, she is to again lead members of the TMC women's wing in a door-to-door programme to take stock of the government's different women-centric schemes.

Compared with Chandrima, Shashi is more soft-spoken but very assertive when the situation demands. She's also methodical, diligent and disciplined in her approach to her duties. "Whatever she does, she does with hundred per cent dedication. Even while taking questions from the Opposition during question hour in the assembly, she's so thorough and detailed that Speaker Biman Banerjee is often heard asking her to table all that she has to spare time for other legislators," says a government official.

As member, Mayor in Council, Kolkata Corporation, Shashi started English-medium corporation schools along with schools with Odia and Urdu as the medium of instruction. She was the first to introduce cooked meals for corporation school students, as well as uniforms, bags and shoes for them. Thus, it was natural that after launching the Kanyashree scheme (a yearly stipend to encourage girls to pursue higher studies) in March 2013, Mamata inducted Shashi in the cabinet as the